

Three Worlds of 2041

How AI could reshape our industry, our customers and our planet over the next 15 years

THREE SCENARIOS, NOT THREE PREDICTIONS

On 6 April 2026, four people watched Earth set behind the Moon. Fifteen years from now, the Moon may be a place where people go to work. This is not a dream. It is three futures we can already see coming, and the choices that decide which one we get.

IN THIS BRIEFING today's signals, our method, three worlds of 2041, the odds, and what to do from Monday.



Mohammad

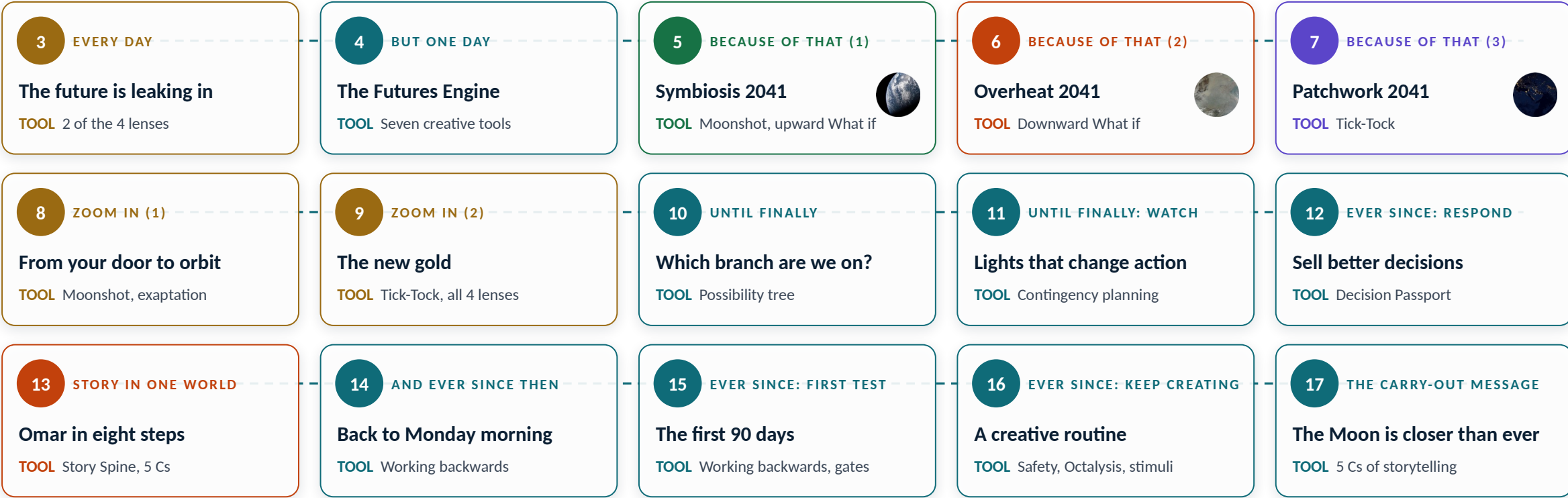
Senior Futures Consultant, Em, Oli & Timmonds

Part 1 | **The Creative Solution**

Earth sets behind the Moon, photographed by the Artemis II crew, 6 April 2026. Image: NASA

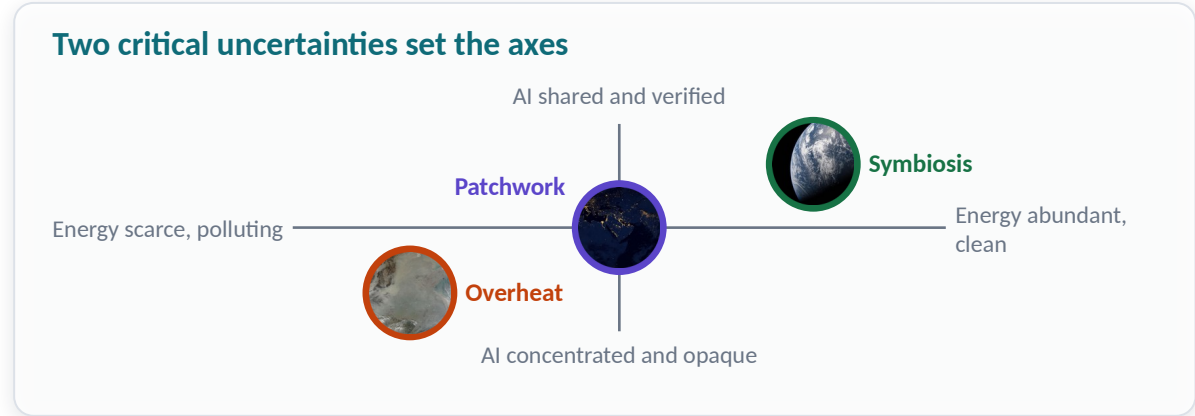
One story, fifteen steps

Our brief: imagine the world in 15 years' time, considering AI's impact on our industry and on the whole world, and decide what E,O&T should build now without betting on one forecast. The story uses an adapted, branching Story Spine: the three "Because of that" steps are alternative worlds. Facts and projections are tagged; the 2041 worlds are imagined scenarios.



SCOPE Industry: strategic consulting | Clients: energy, logistics and digital services | World: work, daily life, infrastructure and the space frontier

How the signals become worlds. Seven tools work like gears, and each produces a visible output on the slides shown. We first ran a controlled What if (keep AI access fixed, change only energy headroom), then combined both uncertainties into three worlds.



Exaptation

Borrowed from air traffic control (one network, many vehicles) and multiplayer game design (rules that shape behaviour).

Shared, verified AI with abundant clean energy



Robots on the Moon (NASA concept)



A DAY IN 2041 | HARD EMPATHY IN 5 STEPS

Layla, 34, grid engineer, Riyadh

Scene: 6 am. My AI agent has already sold my solar surplus and drafted my report.

Feel: free, and strangely idle.

Make sense: the machines now do the routine half of my job.

Worry: what am I still for?

Act: I join the council that designs our city's digital twin.

STORY SPINE **Because of that (1)**

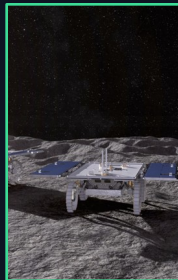
The best case. We push the engine's upper branch to a moonshot, then live one day inside it through hard empathy.



Customers try a flat or a lunar hotel in a live digital twin before buying. White-hat Octalysis: each purchase plants a real tree.



Electric pods and air taxis on one AI network, borrowed from air traffic control. Car parks become parks.



A crewed base at the lunar south pole mines ice for fuel. Robots build; the first tourists arrive.



AI writes the analysis; consultants own the judgement. E,O&T move: launch a future-design practice.

5 Cs

Layla, and every
client like her

AI's hunger for energy

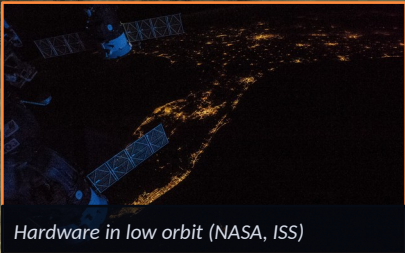
Clean power, efficient chips

Abundance, shared widely

Build the future we
want

Still hard here: e-waste, attention overload, disputes over lunar mining.

Concentrated, opaque AI with scarce, polluting energy



Omar, 41, logistics manager

Scene: in the depot, two delivery alerts contradict each other.

Feel: anxious; the rationing app also limits when I can charge the vans.

Make sense: one of the alerts may be synthetic.

Worry: I could send a driver onto an unsafe route.

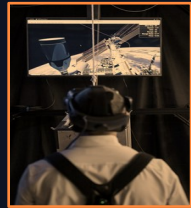
Act: I verify both alerts through our data cooperative before dispatch.

Every utopia has a shadow

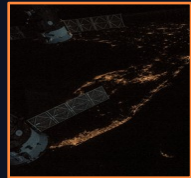
The honest shadow of World 1. Same engine, downward What if, told as a chain of cause and effect.

1

AI demand outran clean power, so fossil plants kept running.



The metaverse is an escape; black-hat Octalysis (scarcity, loss) keeps people hooked.



Space and the Moon

Low orbit is a junkyard; the lunar base waits.



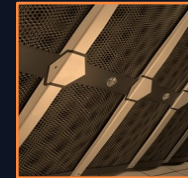
Heat and pollution rose,
and power was rationed.



A few players owned the models; deepfakes broke trust.



Empty robotaxis gridlock the cities.
The rich fly; everyone else waits.



Our industry

Reports cost pennies. E,O&T move:
verification and resilience services.



A debris cascade took out navigation and broadband satellites.

5 Cs

Character
Omar

Conflict

AI outgrows clean power

Cure

None, in time

Change

Trust and orbit lost

Carry-out

Plan for the shadow first

Trust verified inside regional blocs, mixed energy between them

One planet, three rulebooks.



Act: I design one product that passes all three blocs' trust rules.

Neither heaven nor collapse

The middle path, built by flipping two of today's facts with Tick-Tock. Here trust, not technology, decides who wins.

TOCK AI agents buy from AI agents, so firms must design for machine customers.

TOCK Data is owned and paid for, like energy.



Regional metaverses joined by one digital identity, so trust becomes the product.



Driverless in some regions, manual in others; the best cities blend both.



Shared on paper; blocs compete quietly for lunar ice and landing sites.



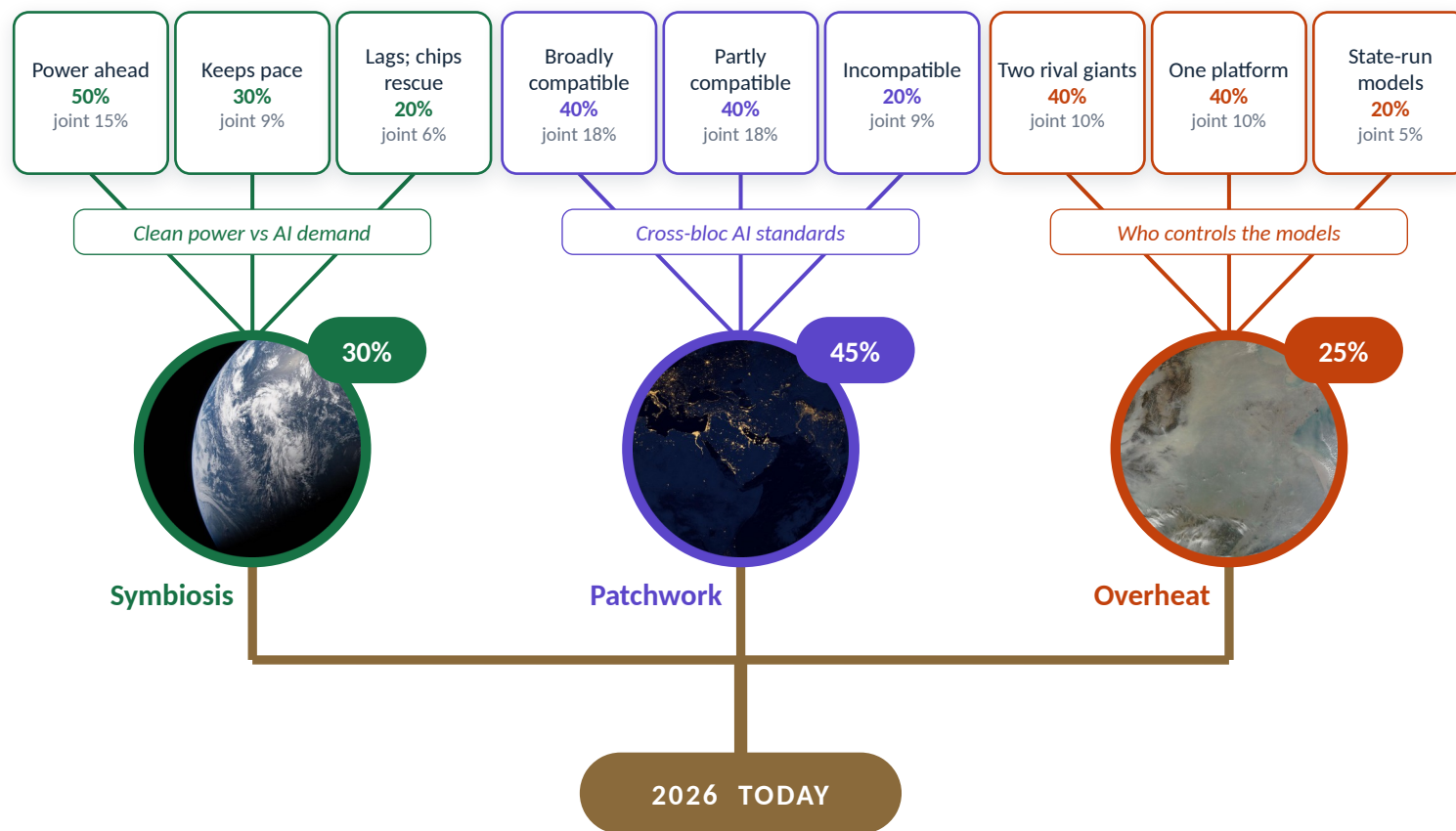
Winners translate between blocs.
E,O&T move: a cross-bloc standards
advisory.

Carry-out

The future is a negotiation

Which branch are we on?

Three worlds with planning weights, then one key driver per world split into three exclusive outcomes. Conditional odds sum to 100% per world, and the joint odds of all nine outcomes sum to 100%. Illustrative judgements, not calibrated forecasts.



How to read the tree

Level 1: worlds

Planning weights for the three worlds: 30%, 45%, 25%. They sum to 100%.

Level 2: one driver each

Three mutually exclusive outcomes per world, with conditional odds that sum to 100% within that world.

Joint odds

World x outcome. Worked example: Patchwork and partly compatible = $45\% \times 40\% = 18\%$. All nine joint odds total 100%.

Why Patchwork leads

AI rules are already splitting by region; the clean-power race is not yet won.

Status

Illustrative judgements to support discussion, not calibrated forecasts.

A light only matters if it changes a decision

Each signpost has a record, a review trigger and a response. Triggers are proposed review rules measured against a pilot baseline, not external benchmarks.

SIGNPOST	WHAT WE RECORD	REVIEW TRIGGER	RESPONSE	POINTS TO
 Clean power for AI	Clean energy built per new data centre; energy used per completed task	Two monthly reviews worse than baseline	Switch to a smaller model or a manual route	Overheat
 Evidence quality	Share of outputs with a traceable source; material errors	Any unmitigated material error	Pause automation; require human approval	Symbiosis or Overheat
 Portability	Time and failures when moving one test case between providers	A second provider fails the same test	Add an adapter; avoid single-provider lock-in	Patchwork
 Orbital access	Debris-removal missions flown; launch delays	Removal still experimental by 2030	Plan ground fallbacks for satellite services	Overheat
 Human agency	Can users understand, challenge and reverse a result?	A high-impact decision has no appeal route	Redesign the handover before scaling	All three worlds

Cadence. The pilot lead records weekly, the client owner reviews monthly, and the team revisits the scenario assumptions every quarter.

Three proposed offers, one per world, share one reusable asset: a Decision Passport that records why a client should act, who owns the decision and what happens if it fails.

DECISION PASSPORT | WORKED EXAMPLE: OMAR'S DISPATCH IN OVERHEAT (ILLUSTRATIVE REHEARSAL)

Proposed service concepts and an illustrative rehearsal, not existing products or results.

What I am taking with me

The tools that resonated, the change in my thinking, and why it matters in my professional life.

Three ideas from this course changed how I think about planning: possibility trees, working backwards, and counterfactual thinking. Together they gave me a structured language for something my work has always demanded: decisions about a future nobody can see.

In twenty years of network engineering and digital transformation, I have learned that a platform chosen today may still shape a business in ten years. Building the three worlds of 2041 for this assignment showed me a different way to approach that kind of decision. Drawing the possibility tree forced me to give each branch a probability, and the less likely branches raised questions a single forecast would never have asked. Working backwards from a 2041 press release, the way Amazon writes the press release before the product exists, made the first steps for 2026 obvious. Counterfactual thinking kept the exercise honest: writing Overheat next to Symbiosis stopped me from falling in love with the optimistic future.

What resonated most is that creativity here is not a talent but a structured skill, wild ideas plus strategy.



20 years

in networks and digital transformation,
where decisions have long consequences

How I will put it into practice

A realistic timetable, a review loop and a personal routine that continues beyond this course.

My plan is concrete. From November, every new technical proposal I write will open with a one-page working backwards brief describing the result for the customer in three years, the assumptions behind it and the first test. Once a quarter, starting in January 2027, I will build a possibility tree for one roadmap decision, with three branches, nine sub-branches and probabilities, and review it three months later to see which branch reality followed. Before each major design review I will run one upward and one downward counterfactual with the team and record the risks it surfaces.

Personally, I live between Riyadh and Stockholm, and I will turn those flights into fuzzy focus time: no screens, just my stimuli queue and a commonplace book, so slow hunches have somewhere to land.

I will measure success simply: by June 2027, I will have built two possibility trees, completed the first three-month review, and recorded whether the findings changed a roadmap decision.



Sources

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Image credits

Slide 1: "A Breathtaking Earthset from Orion", Artemis II crew, 6 April 2026. NASA (art002e021278).

Slide 3: Night Earth observation from the ISS, Expedition 40. NASA (iss040e085126).

Slides 2, 4 and 14: "Home in the Distance", Artemis II. NASA (art002e020922).

Slide 5: "Earth in View", Artemis II (art002e023506); CADRE rovers concept, NASA/JPL-Caltech (PIA26296).

Slide 6: "Haze over eastern China", NASA Goddard (GSFC_20171208_Archive_e001269); ISS Expedition 35 (iss035e017673).

Slides 7, 10 and 17: "Black Marble: Africa, Europe, and the Middle East", NASA Goddard (GSFC_20171208_Archive_e001591).

Slides 5 to 7 and 16: NASA VR training (jsc2026e000427), Advanced Air Mobility concepts (AAM-Concept-2021, automation concept), Mission Control (jsc2026e019925), Pleiades supercomputer (ARC-2008-ACD08-0272-005).

Slide 8: NASA drone flight test (AFRC2026-0152-22); Cygnus in Canadarm2 (iss071e418235); Expedition 66 chile peppers (iss066e023179).

Slide 9: ISS water recovery (iss072e143163); sand dunes and irrigation in Saudi Arabia (PIA11069); Earth limb and Moon (iss051e039977); Veg-01 harvest (iss040e009126); JWST golden mirror (GSFC_20171208_Archive_e000368).

World thumbnails on slides 2, 4, 10, 12, 13 and 17 reuse the images of slides 5, 6 and 7.

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Use of AI

I acknowledge the use of Claude by Anthropic (<https://claude.ai>) and ChatGPT by OpenAI (<https://chatgpt.com>) to help generate and develop scenario ideas and variants, critique and develop wording, framework applications, scenario logic and probabilities, design the Decision Passport, pilot and workshop, find and check sources, and arrange and format the slides. The prompts used include "Propose solution directions for each company and the course concepts they would apply", "Draft three different future scenarios for 2041 with personas, built on the course tools", "Check every slide against the assignment requirements and rubric", "Merge the strongest ideas from my two drafts into one deck" and "Build the deck as a PowerPoint with my photo and a dark cinematic layout". The output was used as a starting point that I selected, reviewed, edited and verified; the choice of company and direction, the final scenarios, and the reflection based on my own experience and plans are mine, and I remain responsible for the submission.